



Photographs by AP

ISHANT SHARMA

In 2007-08, Sharma burst into fame with a spell of top-quality pace bowling in Australia and Today, the speed demon has lost his speed and struggles to make a mark in ODIs

match-winner on his own. He remains a player of "promise" who has produced dazzling innings when in partnership with a senior during a run chase. Injury and a lack of form edged out R.P. Singh, another celebrated rookie, while keeper Dinesh Karthik finds it hard to compete with Dhoni.

As a layer of that CB series squad has disintegrated, two other names have joined the squad: batsman Virat Kohli, captain of the Indian team that won the under-19 World Cup, who

RAVINDRA JADEJA

A 2009 debutant introduced to replace Yusuf Pathan, Jadeja has had early troubles at the international level both at the World T20 Cup and the Australia series

first played for India in Sri Lanka last year and all-rounder Ravindra Jadeja, a 2009 debutant. Barring Jadeja's left-arm spin versus the Aussies and his innings in a losing cause, no spark was sighted.

Younger players do take their time and the second season, like Ishant's, is always tougher than the first. But those that truly matter find footholds quickly. After stutters from 2003 to 2005, Gambhir began to snap into a spate of run-making against major

opposition from his 27th ODI. By his 30th ODI, Yuvraj Singh had pulled out some tight games for India, including a must-win game that prevented an ODI series loss to Zimbabwe in early 2002. His other equally inexperienced partner in the lower middle-order was Mohammed Kaif. Everyone remembers what they did in three month's time at Lord's. The NatWest series win was Yuvraj's 40th ODI match and Kaif's 18th, where he won Man of the Match. Within the next year, India were joint winners of the Champions Trophy and World Cup finalists.

In 15 months, India will be playing a World Cup at home where younger men of mettle would be mandatory.

A former India stalwart says youngsters tend to struggle against pressure and expectation. It is the reason why treating them patiently is necessary. Jadeja's early struggles with the bat were obvious before a longer innings in Guwahati. "He needs a bit more time to adjust to international cricket and its quality".

These days what has also played its part is the IPL explosion that has given an army of younger players bigger pay cheques and instant national fame. More than once, Jadeja has been introduced to cricket's high and mighty by his Rajasthan Royals captain Shane Warne saying, "This guy will be an India star". No chance he would disagree or argue with the great Warne.

Former India quick Venkatesh Prasad, recently national bowling coach said the IPL had made the ODI feel like a four-day game. "Players need to switch formats quickly and be mature in doing so."

New India are not. A current selector admitted, under condition of anonymity, that India's young players were "not fully mentally-prepared, not fully settled in at the international level. We need a lot of A-team cricket going on to get them ready."

Another rethink required he says is in the "youth policy that has taken over the world." Picking an under-19 star like Kohli, has not worked like it needed to. Prasad believes that players should be broken into the national team only after three seasons or 50-

Given that India's Young Turks once were Yuvraj, Sehwag, Dhoni and Harbhajan, it is fair to ask if the new rookies are ready to step up

